

Interjections

INTERJECTIONS ARE WORDS OR PHRASES THAT OCCUR ALONE AND EXPRESS EMOTION.

Interjections are considered a part of speech, but they play no grammatical role in a sentence. They are single words or phrases that are used to exclaim, protest, or command, and rarely appear in formal writing.

Emotional words

Interjections occur frequently in spoken English. They are useful in informal writing—particularly in narratives or scripts—since they help convey the emotions of a character, but they are only used in formal writing as part of a direct quotation. New interjections to describe different emotions are invented all the time, and they vary from region to region.

Emotion	Interjection
pain	ouch, ow, oh
disgust	yuck, ugh, ew
surprise	eek, yikes, ooh, wow, eh, well, really
elation	hooray, yippee, ha, woo-hoo, whoopee
pleasure	mmm, yeah
relief	phew, whew, whoa
boredom	blah, ho-hum
embarrassment	ahem, er
disappointment	aw, meh, pfft
dismay	oh no, oh, oops
panic	help, ah, uh oh
irritation	hmph, huh, hey, oy
disapproval	tsk-tsk, tut-tut
realization	aha, ah
pity	dear, alas, ahh
doubt	hmm, er, um

• Use interjections in moderation, or not at all. They rarely improve a piece of writing.

SEE ALSO

◀ 20–21	Parts of speech
Sentences	68–69 ▶
Colloquialisms and slang	86–87 ▶
Commas	96–99 ▶
Exclamation points	112–113 ▶

Using interjections

Interjections that express strong emotions such as dismay or surprise usually function as exclamations, appearing alone as single words or phrases followed by an exclamation point. Milder emotions tend to be expressed using an interjection followed by a comma.

Uh oh!

This is an exclamation, because it expresses a strong emotion (panic). It is punctuated with an exclamation point.



This mild interjection has been incorporated into a sentence; it is separated from the main part of the sentence by a comma.

Phew, that was scary.

